The Wider Historical Context of *An Inspector Calls*

Please read this resource carefully and consider memorising a specifical contextual fact for each of the 10 topics.

Most importantly however are the sections on the 'Writer's Message' – memorise this for the WHY statements of your essays, where you move from close language analysis to considering the writer's overall arguments.

1. 1912: A World on the Brink

- In 1912, Britain appeared secure: the empire was vast, industry was booming, and the ruling classes felt untouchable.
- Politicians and businessmen like **Arthur Birling** believed in stability and growth, yet Europe was already unstable. Alliances, nationalism, and arms races meant war was imminent.
- The First World War (1914–18) would shatter this illusion, killing millions and exposing the arrogance of leaders who thought peace inevitable.
- Priestley's choice of 1912 is deliberate: it represents a society on the edge of collapse, blind to its own fragility.

- **Priestley's message to his audience:** The smug certainty of the Birlings reflects the blindness of the powerful. Priestley warns his audience that ignoring global tensions and social responsibility leads to disaster.

2. The Edwardian Class System

- Britain's social structure in 1912 was steeply hierarchical. At the top, the aristocracy and the wealthy industrial elite enjoyed political and economic dominance.
- The middle classes (professionals, business owners like **Birling**) aspired to join the ranks of the traditional gentry, often through marriage or honours. Birling is not just an individual businessman but a construct representing capitalist ambition and self-interest.
- The working classes — the majority — had little voice. They endured poor wages, long hours, and inadequate housing, often relying on charities or the harsh Poor Law if they fell into destitution.
- Social mobility was extremely limited, and respectability was tied to wealth and gender, not merit. **Eva Smith** becomes an emblem of these silenced millions, standing in for the exploited and voiceless poor.
- **Priestley's message to his audience:** Inequality and complacency were the causes of much suffering. Priestley highlights the need to break down class barriers and embrace fairness across society.

3. Industrialisation and Workers' Rights

- Britain's wealth in 1912 depended on industry: factories, mills, mines, and shipyards. Owners had immense control, while workers were treated as disposable.
- In this period, trade unions were becoming more assertive, demanding fairer pay and safer conditions. Between 1910–1914, Britain experienced waves of strikes — sometimes called the "Great Unrest."
- Employers like **Birling** often saw workers as troublemakers rather than people with legitimate grievances. In the play, Birling symbolises a callous capitalist class determined to protect profits over people.
- Sacking workers who asked for better pay was common practice. Priestley draws directly on this history: **Eva Smith's** sacking mirrors the industrial disputes of his

own Bradford childhood, making her a construct of working-class resistance and suffering.

- **Priestley's message to his audience:** By dramatising Eva's dismissal, Priestley condemns exploitative capitalism and urges his audience to support workers' rights and humane treatment.

4. Gender Inequality

- Women in 1912 lacked political power and social equality. They could not vote in parliamentary elections, and many occupations were closed to them.
- Working-class women often found employment in factories, domestic service, or shops, but wages were low and jobs insecure. Middle-class women, like **Sheila**, were usually expected to marry well rather than pursue careers. Sheila is emblematic of her class and gender: sheltered yet capable of growth, symbolising the potential for change among privileged young women.
- The suffragette movement (e.g. Emmeline Pankhurst's WSPU) was becoming increasingly militant in 1912, highlighting frustration with the slow pace of reform.
- Women's lives were also constrained by sexual double standards: men like **Gerald** could act freely without censure, while women who stepped outside "respectability," like **Eva**, were stigmatised. Gerald thus represents male privilege, while Eva is a construct exposing the vulnerability of women in a patriarchal society.
- **Priestley's message to his audience:** Priestley critiques a system that left women doubly vulnerable. He asks his audience to confront gender inequality and learn from the progress that had been won since 1912.

5. The Titanic and the Myth of Progress

- The Titanic's launch in April 1912 was seen as the crowning achievement of modern engineering, a symbol of Britain's global power. Its sinking days later was a national shock.
- For Priestley's 1945 audience, the Titanic represented the folly of human arrogance and blind faith in technology and progress.
- **Birling's** misplaced confidence in its safety is not just comic irony but a wider symbol of the overconfidence of his class. He is constructed as the mouthpiece of capitalist complacency.

- By referencing the Titanic, Priestley satirises the hubris of those who believed wealth and power insulated them from disaster.
- **Priestley's message to his audience:** The Titanic epitomises the dangers of arrogance. Priestley encourages his audience to distrust those who place blind faith in progress without considering human consequences.

6. The Shadow of War

- The First World War destroyed the Edwardian world: around 750,000 British soldiers were killed, and many more were wounded. Entire communities lost a generation of young men.
- The war also shook class certainties: men from all backgrounds fought together, and women entered the workforce in unprecedented numbers.
- The Second World War had an even greater impact, with civilian casualties from bombings, the horrors of the Holocaust, and the use of atomic weapons.
- Both wars exposed the cost of selfishness, nationalism, and denial, reinforcing Priestley's belief that only collective responsibility could prevent future catastrophe.
- **The Inspector**, who delivers the warning of "fire and blood and anguish," is more than a character: he is a construct embodying moral truth, conscience, and historical judgement.
- **Priestley's message to his audience:** War is the ultimate price of selfishness. Priestley uses the Inspector's warning to remind audiences that peace depends on solidarity.

7. The Rise of Socialism

- In the early 20th century, the Labour movement was gaining ground, influenced by trade unionism and socialist thinkers.
- The interwar years deepened critiques of capitalism: mass unemployment, poverty, and the Great Depression (1929–1939) convinced many that free-market systems failed ordinary people.
- Priestley became a prominent voice for reform, advocating fairness, equality, and shared responsibility. His wartime broadcasts emphasised unity across class divides.

- **The Inspector** is the clearest embodiment of these ideals. He is a symbolic construct rather than a "real" policeman, a vehicle through which Priestley delivers his socialist thesis.
- **Priestley's message to his audience:** Priestley presents socialism as moral common sense. His audience is urged to embrace collective responsibility rather than individual greed.

8. The Welfare State and 1945 Britain

- After WWII, Britain was determined not to repeat the failures of the interwar years. The Beveridge Report (1942) identified five "giants" to defeat: Want, Disease, Ignorance, Squalor, and Idleness.
- The Labour government of 1945, elected in a landslide, introduced sweeping reforms: the NHS, expanded education, new housing, and greater social security.
- This was a time of optimism: people believed in building a fairer society that would not abandon its weakest members.
- Priestley's play resonated deeply with this context, affirming the values of responsibility, fairness, and social reform.
- **Sybil Birling**, as a symbol of cold-hearted charity and upper-class hypocrisy, is contrasted with the Inspector's vision of genuine social care.
- **Priestley's message to his audience:** The future must not mirror the past. Priestley aligns the Inspector's message with the principles of the new Welfare State, urging audiences to defend fairness and equality.

9. Generational Shifts

- After both wars, many younger people rejected the values of their parents, who were seen as complicit in old systems of privilege and inequality.
- Youth culture in the mid-20th century became increasingly associated with change, modernity, and reform.
- In *An Inspector Calls*, **Sheila** and **Eric** embody this capacity for growth: they accept guilt and show empathy, unlike their parents. As constructs, they represent the hope of generational renewal.
- The older Birlings, by contrast, symbolise entrenched conservatism and denial.

- **Priestley's message to his audience:** Priestley calls on younger generations to lead moral progress. The future depends on their willingness to reject denial and embrace responsibility.

10. History as a Warning

- The play's retrospective structure — set in 1912 but written in 1945 — allows Priestley to use dramatic irony to powerful effect.
- His audience already knows the outcomes: the sinking of the Titanic, two world wars, and social upheaval. The Birlings' optimism is therefore exposed as foolish and dangerous.
- Priestley believed that history had lessons: societies that ignored responsibility invited disaster. The play is both drama and moral allegory, warning against complacency.
- **The Inspector**, as a symbolic figure, becomes the voice of historical judgement. He is less a detective than an emblem of collective conscience, sent to confront denial and hypocrisy.
- The Inspector's final speech crystallises this vision: if people fail to care for one another, they will be taught the lesson "in fire and blood and anguish."
- **Priestley's message to his audience:** Learn from history, or be destroyed by it. Priestley warns his audience that selfishness and denial will always end in tragedy unless society accepts its duty to others.